Thanks to the translations into French and English of Xuanzang's *Great Tang Records on the Western Regions*, Alexander Cunningham and his successors were able to track down virtually every one of the Buddhist centres he visited in India. But what Xuanzang's account also shows is that by his time Buddhism was on the wane and Hinduism very much in the ascendant.

Xuanzang had arrived in Tamil country not long after the Pallavas under the leadership of the warrior-king Mahendravarma had recaptured their former capital at Kanchipuram. Then in 642 CE, at just about the same time as Xuanzang's visit, Mahendravarma's son Narasimhavarman defeated the so-called 'Early Chalukyas' to the north with the aid of an exiled Lankan prince. In return Narasimhavarman lent the prince an army, which he used to invade Lanka and win the throne for himself. Xuanzang was about to set sail for Lanka from Nagapattinam when a party of refugee monks came ashore with news that the Buddhist king of Lanka was dead and the island in turmoil.

Xuanzang was forced to change his plans and move up the west coast, but not before he had taken note of a sacred mountain on the eastern flank of the Malaya mountains known to him as 'Po-ta-lo-ka'. On its summit was a stone palace frequented – not by Agastya but by the Buddhist Bodhisattva Avalokiteshvara! By his account, pilgrims hoping to see Avalokiteshvara in his palace on this Potala peak had to risk their lives by climbing the mountain. Those who succeeded were granted an apparition of Avalokiteshvara – not as himself but, in Xuanzang's words, 'as a *Pashupatha Tirthaka* or as *Mahesvara*'. Maheshvara, or 'great lord', is an epithet for Lord Shiva, and a Pashupatha Tirthaka is an ascetic devotee of Shiva, so by Xuanzang's time Shaivas were firmly in control of this holy mountain, whether as Potala, Pothigai or Agastya Malai. This also helps to explain why in Tamil Buddhist accounts it is